Freak: A Semi-Demi-Quasi-Pseudo Autobiography

By John Leguizamo

(Cutting revised 1/29/2024)

INTRODUCTION

(Very formally) John Leguizamo was born in Bogotá, Colombia. His father Alberto was a Puerto Rican realtor when met Leguizamo's mother, Luz.

JOHN: *(interrupting)* ***(Pg 2-3)*** I've changed my parents' names to Fausto and Lala, to protect the innocent, namely me. And when I was born, my moms was in labor for forty-eight hours!

MOMS: Desgraciado, get this parasite out of me! Get it out of me now!!

DOCTOR: Push! MS. Liquidzamo, Mrs. Legs and amo, leg of lab . . . Just push ma'am!

DAD: I'm paying you, doctor! Why don't you pull?

DOCTOR: I am pulling! He's stubborn.

DAD: Then leave him in there. Get up, woman, we're leaving,

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JOHN: And they wonder why I have problems.

(Shrugs shoulders) I'll let John tell it his way. Freak: A Semi-Demi-Quasi-Pseudo Autobiography by John Leguizamo

JOHN: **(Pg 3-4)** My parents left Latin American during the big plantain famine of the late sixties and when they arrived in New York City they had such thick accents they couldn't even understand each other. My moms got all her English from watching television.

MOMS: Fausto, chock full of nuts is the heavenly coffee, they're creepy and they're cookie, that . . . that . . . that's all folks!

DAD: Woman, what the hell did you just say?

MOMS: How should I know? I'm speaking English.

JOHN: **(Pg 5-6)** The shuttle from the airport said "Miserable and Huddled Masses" and my pops is like, "This is our bus," so we jumped on and ended up in the present-day Ellis Island – Jackson Heights, Queens. Our tenement building was like the modern Tower of Babel. When I walked through the streets, I'd see every ethnicity under the sun.

HINDI GUY: You want curry candy?

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JAMAICAN RASTA: You people multiply like roaches. Tinga linga ling. Hear the money ring.

KOREAN NEWSTAND GUY: This is not a library, You buy magazine or kick your a**!

JOHN: My parents worked twenty-eight hours a day, fourteen days a week. I'm not bad at math; it's just that Latin people have to make the most of their time. But my pops always took time out of his busy schedule to tell us his own version of an American bedtime story.

DAD: Once upon a time there was a Little Red Riding Hood and she went into the woods and got a green card and lived happily ever after. Now shut up and go to sleep!

JOHN: **(Pg 14-20)** Now, our apartment was so puny it wished it were a project. It was a seventies nightmare; our walls were avocado green with brown linoleum and a nuclear orange shag rug. And the centerpiece, the piece de resistance of this mess, was our TV, my dad's pride and joy. It was sacred to him, because my pops could Latinize everybody in America; we would let the screen get real dusty so that everybody looked nice and dark and Spanish. He thought the more you watch it, the more you wear it out. Dad was operating under some kind of third-world logic.

DAD: Don't use my television and don't sit on my furniture

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unless we have important guests. Use the floor for sitting and the kitchen sink for eating. And we're not gonna buy any more food if you keep eating it! Food, I repeat, is for the guests and the animals. And I just brushed the dogs, so don't pet 'em! And get off the rug, I just vacuumed it. And stop sucking up all my oxygen -- I'm breathing it.

JOHN: My brother and I would be like, "Okay, Dad, okay." Every time my father had something important to say, the subway would go by. And it wouldn't have been a problem, but we shared a wall with the number 7 Train. He'd start lecturing us

DAD: I'm only gonna say this once. The most important thing I want you to do is. . .

JOHN: And sure enough the train would roar by, drowning him out

DAD: . . . or I'm gonna kick you're a**!

JOHN: Paralyzed with fear, I'd say, "Okay, Dad-no problem." But as soon as my father was out of the house, my brother Poochie and I would be like a Navy SEAL operation. *(to Poochie)* Now, Poochie, it's 1800 hours, and the Prince of Darkness will be. . . *(to audience)* Poochie freaked out.

POOCHIE: Prince of Darkness? You didn't tell me nuttin' about no Price of Darkness. Na-ah, I'm not listening. *(puts his hands over his ears and closes his eyes)* Mamaku mamasa mama mamakusa

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. . .

JOHN: *(yelling)* Poochie! The Prince of Darkness is the man you know as Dad. Now you go put the bubble wrap under the rug so when Dad comes through the hall, we'll hear him. Now we're punishmentproof. We outsmarted that ignor-anus! What a maroon! What a suckerbutt! Ha ha! *(dancing)* ***Ungawa ungawa, Dad's away for two hours. A beep beep, we're TV freaks. Get stupid.*** Poochie, turn the TV on. *(to audience)* Then we'd settle down for a TV frenzy -- *Spiderman*, *Underdog*, *Gigantor* the space robot. Everything was great until I messed with the antenna. *(pantomime Spiderman)* I'd be swinging around in time to the Spiderman theme when suddenly. . . *(freeze)* SNAP! The blood drained out of my body and into the ground and back to Latin America. *(wailing)* Poochie, I broke the antenna! *(think rabbit ear antennas on the top of the television)*

MOMS: *(climbing in through the window)* John!

JOHN: *(heavy sigh of relief)* Luckily it was just my moms. Mom. Why are you climbing in through the window?

MOMS: The rent is due. What are you doing? You're sitting in the furniture. You're eating the food. Ay, dios mio, you broke the antenna!! Oh my God! I'm looking into the face of a dead boy.

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JOHN: Moms had a knack for calming me down. *(to Moms, hysterical begging)* Mom, use me for cruel animal experimentation but don't let him get his hands on me!!!

MOMS: No, don't, don't. I'll miss you. But now I must distance myself. Come, Poochie, you're an only child now. Ciao. Get off me, John. Get off.

JOHN: Then all of a sudden, we hear the sound of snapping bubble wrap . . .

DAD: *(cursing)* ***Cono, que es toda esta mierda de bubble wrap, hijo de puta!***

JOHN: So, I'm blowing and fanning the TV 'cause my pops would feel it for heat. And my moms goes into rescue mode

MOMS: *(whispering)* I'll take care of your father. *(trying to distract Dad)* Fausto, you look so ultra sexy. You look so sexy. Yes, you do. You and me. Okay?

JOHN: But my father wasn't taking the bait.

DAD: Woman, I just wanna watch my television.

MOMS: Okay, then, why don't you go downstairs and play some pool. Hmm? Okay? Play some pool?"

JOHN: God bless my moms. We didn't have a downstairs. Pops turned on the TV.

DAD: I said no, woman. What's all that static. I can't tell Sonny from Cher.

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JOHN: I'll fix it! I'll fix it! *(to audience)* So I moved the good piece of antenna for all I was worth. *(to Dad)* Like this, Dad? Or this? Here?

DAD: Move the other one!

JOHN: *(Pantomime frantically while speaking)* So I pretended to move the broken antenna. I frantically shifted my body around while holding the broken antenna in place. *(to Dad)* There? Like so? Perfect?

DAD: Move away from that television. Get out of the room!

JOHN: Okay, I'm leaving the room, the neighborhood. . . *(to audience)* and as I head for the door, I trip. He sees the antenna came off in my hand. *(to Dad, meekly)* It's a spear and I'm a hunter? *(to audience)* I know what's coming next. My pops field-goals me with a kick across the room. Luckily, the nice hard brick wall broke my fall. And I remembered my comics and how Spiderman once said to Ironman: "To escape the pain, one must move toward the pain." And my soul thought, "Yeah, right!" and . . . BOOM . . . The first words out of my mouth said it all: *(pointing)* Poochie broke the antenna! Poor, slow, chubby Poochie. And I just stood there watching the only brother I had beaten with the antenna, and all I could think was, "Thank God it's not me!"

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AWARD HISTORY

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